



Packaging and labelling your food or drink

K

Know

Useful things to know

Why is packaging important?

- Packaging protects your food from things that can make your food unsafe or unsuitable such as [bugs](#), chemicals, and foreign material.
- Anything that touches food packaging may also make your food unsafe or unsuitable when packaging is removed.

Why is labelling important?

- Labels inform customers of what is in your food.
- Some of your customers will have medical conditions (for example allergies) which require them to include or avoid certain foods in their diet.
- Foods can become unsafe over time, even though they still might look, smell and taste OK. Customers need to know how long food can be kept before it becomes unsafe.
- You need to make sure you calculate the shelf life of your product correctly (that is 'Use By Date', 'Best Before Date' or Baked On/Baked For date).



- Bread: The Baked On/Bkd On or Baked For/Bkd For date can only be used on bread with a shelf-life of less than 7 days.

Selecting and using packaging

- Unsafe and/or unsuitable packaging can make your food unsafe. You need to know that the packaging you use is food-grade and designed to keep food safe.

- Only use packaging that does not cause, or contribute to, food becoming unsafe or unsuitable.
- Check that packaging is food grade when you buy it. Either:
 - purchase packaging labelled as being suitable for food, or
 - get an assurance from your supplier that it is suitable for food.

► Labelling your food

- Not all foods have to be labelled, but for those that do, the labels must meet the rules in the Australia New Zealand Food Standards Code ([the Code](#)). See www.foodstandards.gov.au/food-standards-code/legislation.



- MPI has developed guides to help you work out if you need a label, and what needs to be on it. They can be found at www.mpi.govt.nz/food-business/labelling-composition-food-drinks/.



- Allergic reactions can kill people or make them very sick. It is important that allergens are correctly named and clearly identified on your labels, see '[Allergens and knowing what is in your food](#)' [orange] card and www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/50725.
- Consistency in the layout of label (for example having a nutrition information panel and using minimum font sizes) enables your customers to choose the right food for them.
- If you are supplying bulk foods these will generally need to be accompanied with a packing or specification sheet. You must supply the same information that would go on the food label.





- Even if you are selling food made and packaged by others, it's your responsibility to check that the food is labelled correctly.
- Food may be imported with labels that don't meet the requirements under the Code, but the labelling must be correct when it is sold in New Zealand.



- MPI has developed labelling guides to help you create your food labels. They can be found at www.mpi.govt.nz/food-business/labelling-composition-food-drinks/documents/.



- MPI has developed this guide to help you meet your requirements: 'A guide to alcoholic drinks' www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/31404-a-guide-to-alcoholic-drinks-whats-in-them-and-how-to-label.



- Wine labels need to meet the rules in the Code, unless the wine is for export and the labelling requirements for that particular market are different and you are following these. Grape wine variety, vintage or area of origin labelling requirements may differ from domestic requirements if set in an OMAR. See '[Meeting export requirements \(wine only\)](#)' [orange] card.



- Follow 'A guide to New Zealand honey labelling' www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/26491-a-guide-to-new-zealand-honey-labelling.



- Raw milk cheese is unsafe for vulnerable people (the young, the old, pregnant women and the immunocompromised). It's important that they know if a product is made with raw milk.

Calculating shelf life

- You may need to work out the shelf-life of a food so that you can apply either a Use-By or Best Before date. There is a guide to help you work out shelf-life. Follow 'How to determine the shelf-life of food' www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/12540-How-to-determine-the-shelf-life-of-food-Guidance-document.
- Note: Food that has a shelf-life of more than 2 years, or is an individual portion of ice cream or ice confection (for example a popsicle) does not need to be date marked.



Rules you must follow

Packaging

- If you are packaging food you must:
 - ensure packaging will not cause, or contribute to, food becoming unsafe or unsuitable,
 - identify whether you need to either:
 - label your food, or
 - provide a packing or specification sheet with bulk foods,
 - calculate the food's shelf-life.

Labelling

- Foods that require a label must meet the relevant standards in the Code. You must ensure any allergens are correctly named and identified.

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- Labels (or specification sheets) must include:
 - name of the food,
 - lot/batch identification,
 - name and address of your New Zealand or Australian business,
 - advisory statements, warning statements and allergen declarations where required,
 - any conditions for storage and use,
 - ingredients list, including a statement if the product is made with raw milk (not required for standardised alcoholic drinks),
 - Use By date or Best Before date of the food (not required for food or drink with a shelf-life of more than 2 years),
 - net contents
 - nutrition information panel (not required for alcoholic drinks- unless a nutrition content claim is made),
 - (alcoholic beverages) number of standard drinks,
 - alcohol content (by volume),
 - you can't make health claims about alcoholic drinks, but you can make nutrition content claims about carbohydrate, energy and gluten,
 - a pregnancy warning label if the alcohol content is above 1.15%
 - (grape wine) any claims about the variety, vintages, area of origin must be made in descending order.
 - (grape wine) if you are exporting wine, any compositional claims on the label may need to meet the OMAR for that particular market. See '[Meeting export requirements \(wine only\)](#)' [orange] card.



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- (grape wine) if any grapes, juice, wine or spirits used from another country is added to your wine you must include this other country on your label.
 - information about any characterising ingredients (not required for standardised alcoholic drinks)
 - information about nutrition, health and related claims (only if you've made a claim),
 - identify the inclusion or presence of any genetically modified or irradiated foods.
- If your food does not have to be labelled, you must still be able to tell your customers:
 - what is in the food,
 - information about any characterising ingredients
 - any applicable advisory statements, warning statements and allergen declarations.

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Show

Things to show your verifier

- Show your verifier:
 - how you know that any packaging you use is suitable,
 - your labels and/or specification sheets and how you know what to put on them,
 - how you know your grape wine label statements about grape variety, vintage or area of origin are correct and true,
 - (grape wine) how you know your label complies with any requirements for labelling specified in any applicable OMAR,
 - how you calculate the shelf-life of your products (if applicable).

